

similar action-adventure titles like AC: Valhalla, and Gears 5. I also tried playing some RTS games like Age of Mythology and Warcraft 3: The Frozen Throne and although they run fine I just can't control them with a controller-based layout.

On the back, you can find triggers and bumper buttons, a volume rocker, a power switch that doubles as a fingerprint reader, a headphone socket, a Micro SD card reader, and a docking port that also contains a USB-C port for charging. This can be a little tricky to spot at first, as it's black and slightly recessed from the white casing, but once I found it, I could hit the charging target every time. There are two more buttons underneath, cleverly positioned so my fingers can hit them while I'm holding the device. The entire casing is shaped very much like a game controller, with bulges at the sides I can hold on to while keeping my thumbs on the sticks. It's comfortable to hold, and not too heavy either. More on that later.

Also, there's a cheap piece of white vacuum-formed plastic in the box that acts as a stand. It works, in that it supports the Ally in an upright position and prevents it from falling over, but it seems a bit out of place given the build quality on display elsewhere.

Display

The Ally, at 11 inches wide and weighing 1.34 pounds, seems pretty similar to the Steam Deck in size. But don't let that fool you - the ROG is actually a lot smaller because it's only 0.83 inches thick, which is half the thickness of the Steam Deck. It also only has two rear paddles instead of four, and there are no little touchpads in front like the ones Valve includes. This might be a bummer if you were hoping to play games that usually need a mouse and keyboard. When it comes to the display, Ally's screen is definitely one of its best features. It's a 120Hz



panel and its 1080p resolution is sharper than the Steam Deck's 800p. Plus, the Ally is way more colourful and a bit brighter at around 500 nits compared to around 400 nits on Valve's handheld. When you put them side by side, there's no contest — Ally's screen is way more vibrant and detailed, which is super helpful when you're trying to read small tooltips on a small screen.

Since it is primarily a gaming device its colour accuracy is decent at best. With an average Delta E value of 3.1 and a max value of 7.3, it is not something that encourages you to do some professional-grade colour correction. However, the display has 95.9% sRGB colour space coverage meaning punchy colour reproduction while gaming, or surfing the web. The ROG Ally also has 73.1% DCI-P3 colour space coverage

as well. Both these figures are similar to what you'd expect in a high-refresh-rate powered gaming laptop around the same price range.

Software

One of ROG Ally's standout features is the Armory Crate Launcher, which collates all of your Steam, Xbox games, and games installed on the hard drive into one menu. This makes it easy to switch between games and launchers, but it also highlights one of the device's main issues: its reliance on the Windows desktop mode. This can be fiddly and inconvenient on the device's small screen, and it's a constant reminder that the ROG Ally is more of a miniature PC than a dedicated handheld gaming device.

The ROG Ally's battery life is another major drawback. During high-end gaming, the device's battery life can be as short as an hour, making it unsuitable for gaming on the go. This, combined with the device's size and weight, means that the ROG Ally is more of a home-based gaming device than a truly portable one. The Asus ROG Ally is a Windows-based device that stands out for its ability to run any Windows-based apps, making it a versatile choice for both gaming and general use. It comes with Asus's own software, including the Armoury Crate, which provides a unified game library, pulling games from all installed game stores or clients.

Navigating the Ally is intuitive, though it has its quirks. The device offers different control modes, including gamepad and desktop mode, which you can switch between depending on your needs. However, the "Auto" Control Mode, which should swap between modes when appropriate, can sometimes be less than perfect. The Ally can also connect to an external display, but it only has one USB-C port, so a dock is recommended. It's compatible with Asus' separate XG Mobile eGPU for